

Positive Emotions: Expanding the Repertoire of Pleasure (Isen, 1987)

Alice Isen is a pioneer in the examination of positive emotions. Dr. Isen found that, when experiencing mild positive emotions, we are more likely

1. To help other people.
2. To be flexible in our thinking
3. To come up with solutions to our problems.
4. to be more willing to exhibit self-control

Positive Affect and altruism

In classic research, Isen performed an experimental manipulation in which the research participants either did or did not find coins (placed there by the researcher) in the change slot of a public pay phone. Compared to those who did not find a coin, those who did were more likely to help another person carry a load of books or to help pick up another's dropped papers. Therefore, the finding of a coin and the associated positive emotion made people behave more altruistically.

Positive Affect and Problem-Solving

Feeling positive emotion also can help in seeing problem-solving options and finding cues for good decision making. In one study related to these latter points, the researchers randomly assigned physicians to an experimental condition in which the doctor either was or was not given a small bag that contained 6 hard candies and 4 miniature chocolates (the doctors were not allowed to eat the candy during the experiment). Those physicians who had, rather than had not, been given the gift of candy displayed superior reasoning and decision making relative to the physicians who did not receive the candy. Specifically, the doctors in the positive emotion condition did not jump to conclusions; they were not cautious even though they arrived at the diagnosis sooner than the doctors in the other condition.

Positive Emotions & Life Expectancy

Danner et al. (2001) studied positive emotions and life expectancy. He took handwritten autobiographies from 180 Catholic nuns and scored for emotional content and related to survival during ages 75 to 95. A strong inverse association was found between positive emotional content in these writings and risk of mortality in late life.

A Balanced View of Human Functioning

- Pathology approach is not wrong but is incomplete in its portrayal of humankind. Undeniably, the negative is part of humankind, but only a part. Positive psychology offers a look at the other side that which is good and strong in humankind.
- Future psychologists must develop an inclusive approach that examines both the weaknesses and the strengths of people, as well as the stressors and the sources in the environment.

Basic human emotions

Paul Ekman (2003), a leading researcher on the study of human emotions and expression, posits that there are six basic human emotions found throughout the world, across gender, age and culture. These include: anger, disgust, fear, joy, sadness, and surprise. Another theorist, Izard, argues that we have ten basic emotions including: anger, contempt, disgust, distress, fear, guilt, interest, joy, shame and surprise. Of course other researchers have offered alternative theories, however these are the most robust.

So for those of us who can, and do, feel emotions on a regular basis, what impact do they have on our life, our thinking, behaviours and overall wellbeing and why do we have them in the first place? Well, the evolutionary benefits of negative emotions are clear: they narrow our thought-action repertoires (or, simply speaking, what we think about and the range of actions we are engaged in) to those that best promoted our ancestors' survival in life-threatening situations.

They are also associated with specific action tendencies. Thus, fear makes us want to run, and anger makes us want to thrash out at the aggressor.

The human brain's ability to hone in on real or potential danger is a left-over byproduct of evolutionary and adaptive tendencies. Humans and animals have a tendency or bias towards attending to negative rather than positive stimuli.

Thousands of years ago, people survived if they were able to selectively attend to danger or dangerous situations that could lead to extinction of their genetic line. Although once useful, this selectivity can lead us to narrow in consciously on what is wrong, rather than what is right with ourselves and the world around us. However, recent studies have shown that people who score high on self-reported experiences of positive emotions have an attention bias toward positive information (Strauss and Allen, 2006).

Which positive emotions are important? From decades of research across many populations, ten positive emotions are the most widely researched, as well as experienced in daily life. In order of occurrence, Fredrickson's top ten positive emotions include: joy, gratitude, serenity, interest, hope, pride, amusement, inspiration, awe and love (Fredrickson, 2009). Love is unique in that it encompasses all other nine emotions and can be elicited through the presence of the others. Therefore, love is arguably the most experienced human emotion.

But what use are positive emotions and do they have any action repertoires? This leads us to the 'broaden-and-build' theory of positive emotions. Fredrickson commenced work on her groundbreaking and widely accepted theory of the broaden-and-build functions of positive emotions (Fredrickson, 2001) in the early 1990s. Her research, in several laboratory-controlled experiments, has demonstrated that positive emotions broaden our thought-action repertoires, undo negative emotions and build resilience (Cohn and Fredrickson, 2009).

Building on Isen's work, Fredrickson (2000) has developed a new theoretical framework, the broaden-and-build model of positive emotions, which may provide some explanations for the robust (powerful) social and cognitive effects of positive emotional experiences. In Fredrickson's review of models of emotions

(Smith, 1991), she found that responses to positive emotions have not been extensively studied and that, when researched, they were examined in a vague and underspecified manner. Furthermore, action tendencies generally have been associated with physical reactions to negative emotions (imagine “fight or flight”), whereas human reactions to positive emotions often are more cognitive than physical. For these reasons, she proposes discarding the specific action tendency concept (which suggests a restricted range of possible behavioral options) in favor of a newer, more inclusive term, momentary thought–action repertoires (which suggest a broad range of behavioral options; imagine “taking off blinders” and seeing available opportunities).

The broadening effect

Fredrickson’s positive emotions lab has repeatedly tested the broadening effects of positive emotions. They propose that when we experience one of the main positive emotions, our minds tend to open up – or broaden – and we are able to think ‘outside the box’. This is important because when we broaden our thinking patterns we tend to get a bird’s-eye view of our situation, which can help generate alternative solutions to the tasks at hand. We also become more creative, with positive emotions being found to enhance verbal creativity tasks.

The building effect

Positive emotions do not only open our mind to alternative strategies – research has shown that the experience of positive emotions coupled with the broadening effect has the ability to build personal resources, which we are able to dip into when needed. These include intellectual resources (problem solving, being open to learning), physical resources (cardiovascular health, coordination), social resources (we can maintain relationships and create new ones) and psychological resources (resilience, optimism, sense of identity and goal orientation).² As these develop, they induce more positive emotions that continue building the resources in an upward spiral (see Figure 2.1).

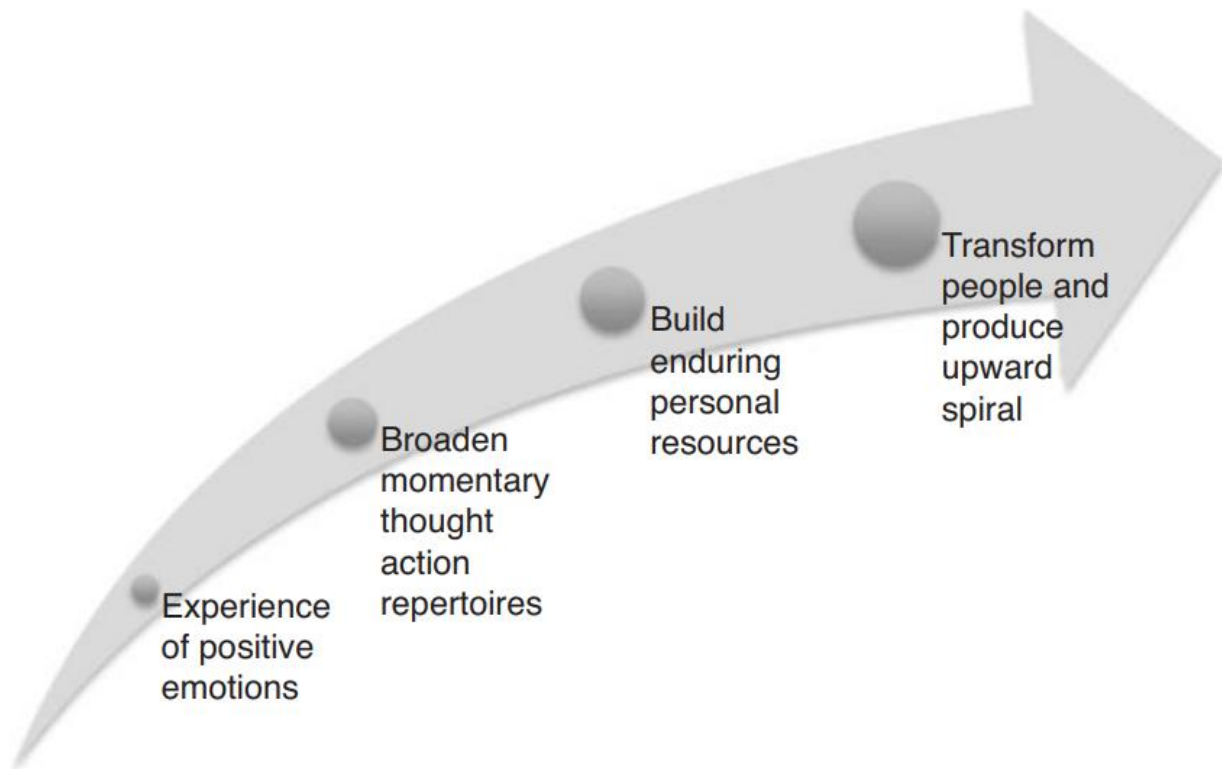
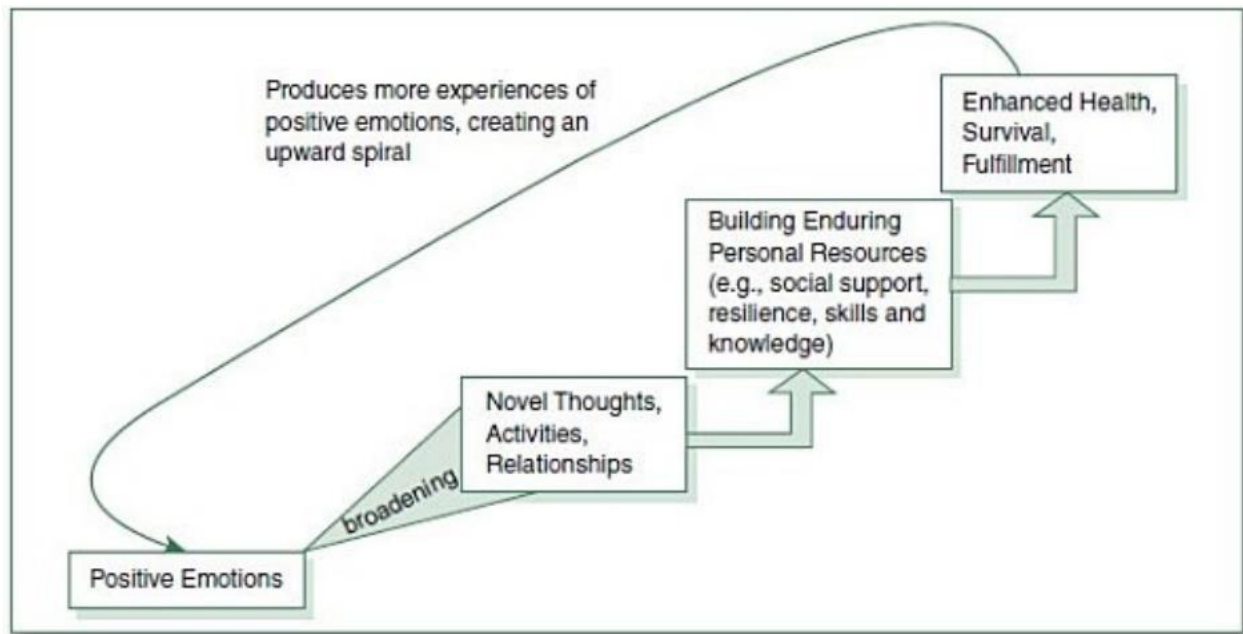
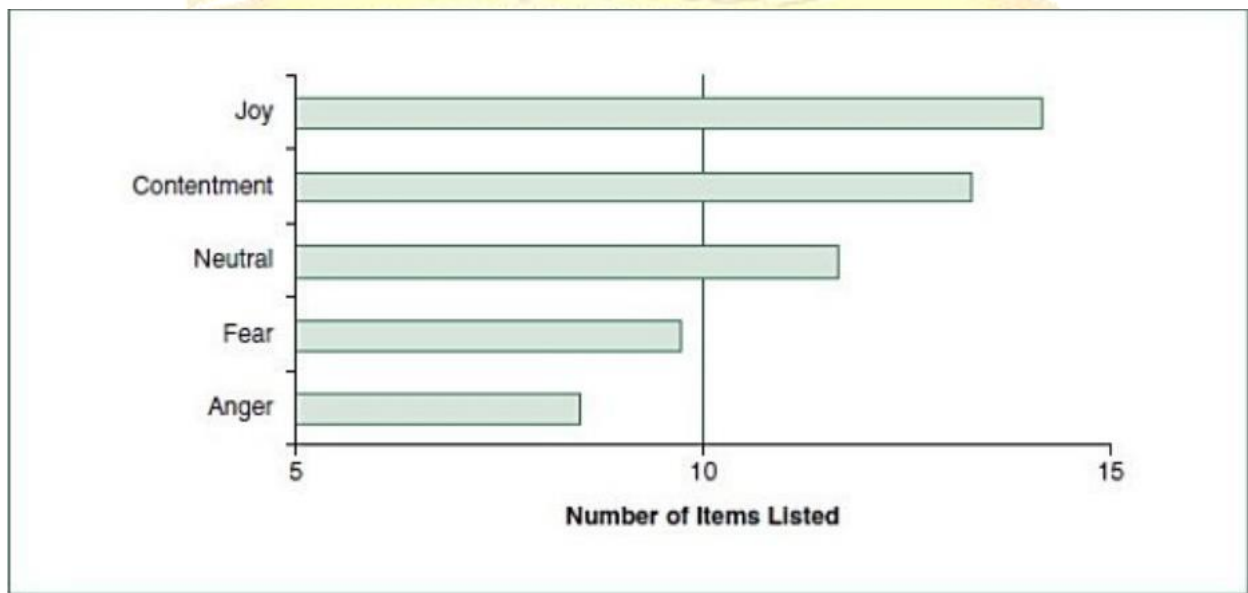


FIGURE 2.1 The broaden-and-build theory of positive emotions (Fredrickson, 2001)

In testing her model of positive emotions, Fredrickson (2000) demonstrated that the experience of joy expands the realm of what a person feels like doing at the time; this is referred to as the broadening of an individual's momentary thought action repertoire. Following an emotion-eliciting film clip (the clips induced one of five emotions: joy, contentment, anger, fear, or a neutral condition), research participants were asked to list everything they would like to do at that moment (see the results in Figure 6.1). Those participants who experienced joy or contentment listed significantly more desired possibilities than did the people in the neutral or negative conditions. In turn, those expanded possibilities for future activities should lead the joyful individuals to initiate subsequent actions. Those who expressed more negative emotions, on the other hand, tended to shut down their thinking about subsequent possible activities. Simply put, joy appears to open us up to many new thoughts and behaviors, whereas negative emotions dampen our ideas and actions.

Figure 6.1 The Broadening Effects of Positive Emotions



Source: Fredrickson (2002). Used with permission of Oxford University Press, Inc.

Joy also increases our likelihood of behaving positively toward other people, along with aiding in developing more positive relationships. Furthermore, joy induces playfulness (Frijda, 1994), which is quite important because such behaviors are

evolutionarily adaptive in acquisition of necessary resources. Juvenile play builds (1) enduring social and intellectual resources by encouraging attachment, (2) higher levels of creativity, and (3) brain development (Cohn & Fredrickson, 2009; Fredrickson, 2002). Playfulness is now also being studied in adults with more positive results. Young adults who are more playful have less perceived stress and are found to cope better with various stressors in their lives (Magnuson & Barnett, 2013). Other research has found that playfulness can be linked to greater life satisfaction (Proyer, 2012) and other positive attributes (Proyer & Ruch, 2011).

The undoing effect

The next time you are faced with a stressful experience, think about the undoing effect of positive emotions. The undoing effect is simply the theory that 'positivity can quell or undo cardiovascular after-effects of negativity' (Fredrickson, 2009: 105). Thus, when we feel anxiety or stress or any other negative emotions, experiencing positive emotions can help our bodies return to normal physiological functioning significantly faster than any other types of emotion (Fredrickson and Levenson, 1998). Research is now under way to discover whether or not this extends to cognitive tasks, such as pattern recognition (Falkenstein et al., 2009).

The broaden-and-build theory states that the experiences of positive emotions broaden the person's momentary thought-action repertoires whereas the negative emotions narrow down the thought-action repertoires; and hence, the positive emotions can also function in ways to 'undo' the effects of the negative emotions. This is called the undoing hypothesis (Fredrickson & Levenson, 1998).

Undoing potential of positive emotions

Positive emotions such as joy may help generate resources, maintain a sense of vital energy (i.e., more positive emotions), and create even more resources. Fredrickson (2002) referred to this positive sequence as the "upward spiral" of positive emotions.

Extending her model of positive emotions, Fredrickson and colleagues examined the “undoing” potential of positive emotions and the ratio of positive to negative emotional experiences that is associated with human flourishing. Fredrickson et al. (2000) hypothesized that, given the broadening and building effects of positive emotions, joy and contentment might function as antidotes to negative emotions. Positive emotions may “undo” the lingering effects of negative emotions. Theorists have proposed that many negative emotions have evolved from life-threatening situations (win-lose). They narrow our thought-action repertoires by calling for specific action tendencies (Anger = urge to attack; Fear = urge to escape). These action tendencies narrow our thoughts to specific urges & ready the body for action. Certain negative emotions, then, result in cardiovascular reactivity, which if prolonged could place one at higher risk for coronary heart disease. Experiencing positive emotions may result in a faster return to activation levels better suited for a wider range of cognitive & behavioral response options (more flexible thinking & action). Complete the Table given below which strategies of positive emotions you have or haven’t employed for undoing the effects of negative emotions.

Fredrickson et al., (2000) conducted an experiment to test the undoing hypothesis. The participants were first induced a high arousal negative emotion and then by random assignment; immediately induced mild joy, contentment, neutrality or sadness by showing short, emotionally evocative film clips. The results showed that the participants in the mild joy and contentment (two positive emotion conditions) exhibited faster cardio-vascular recovery than those in the neutral control condition and faster than those in the sadness condition. There are individual differences in the ability to make use of the undoing effect of the positive emotions. Block & Kremen (1996) found that people who score high on the self-report measures of psychological resilience show faster cardio-vascular recovery after the negative emotional arousal as compared to the people who score low of psychological resilience.

Highly resilient people experience more positive emotions than the less resilient people. The experience of the positive emotions helps them bounce back from the negative emotional arousal. Thus, the resilient people are experts in harnessing the undoing effect of the positive emotions.

Intervention Programs:

There are no techniques or interventions directly based on the broaden-and-build theory for increasing the prevalence of positive emotions. However, the broaden-and-build theory can explain the effectiveness of the existing techniques that can be reframed to increase the prevalence of the positive emotions.

There are no direct methods for inducing emotions among people. All the emotion inducing techniques are indirect in nature; they often focus on one component of the multi-component system. Emotions typically arise from the appraisals of the personal meaning of the of a specific event thus, the most useful emotion inducing technique is to shape the person's appraisals of a situation. The most effective technique is to recalling situations that elicit certain emotions. The other emotion-inducing techniques include a facial or a muscle configuration, a physiological state or a mode of thinking.

The interventions that have been discussed in this section are practicing relaxation and increasing pleasant activities.

Practicing Relaxation:

The various relaxation techniques range from meditation and yoga to imagery exercises and progressive muscle relaxation. These techniques have shown to produce relaxation and help treat problems caused or exacerbated by the negative emotions. The relaxation techniques are highly effective as they initiate the positive emotion of contentment (Fredrickson, 2000).

Contentment is a positive emotion that elicits cognitive changes rather than the physical changes. It integrates the present moment with the experiences into an enriched appreciation of one's place in the world (Fredrickson, 1998 & 2000). The relaxation techniques create conditions for experiencing the positive emotions by inducing the key components of contentment.

The Mediation exercises induce a state of mindfulness (full awareness of the present moment) that resemble the characteristic of contentment. The use of Imagery exercises, focus on specific situations (nature, previous experiences)

known to be frequent precursors of contentment. Use of Progressive Muscle Relaxation creates tension-release sequence which gives way for relaxed contentment. The various relaxation techniques induce the components of contentment which further increases the probability of multi-component experience of contentment. The relaxation techniques are effective in treating problems caused by negative emotions because of the undoing effect of the positive emotions (Fredrickson, 2000). In the long term, the use of relaxation techniques can be useful for psychological growth and well-being.

Increasing Pleasant Activities:

The behavioural theories suggest that depression is caused due to deficit in response-dependent positive reinforcement. The interventions focusing on increasing the pleasant activities are based on the behavioural theories. The various interventions include; increasing the engagement of pleasant activities like being physically active (exercising), being creative, being close to the nature and socializing.

These interventions place emphasis on pleasant activities and not on pleasant subjective experiences (positive emotions). Although pleasant activities are capable of producing positive emotions, to what extent it happens depends on the subjective meanings attached by the individuals to those activities. The effectiveness of these interventions can be accelerated by increasing the pleasant activities and connecting it to the broadening and building effects of the positive emotions (Fredrickson, 2000).

Folkman (1997) suggested that positive emotions result from finding positive meaning. People find positive meaning in the activities and events of day-to-day life by reattaching those events and activities with positive values. In this context, engaging in physical activity can be viewed as personal achievement, attending a social event can be viewed as an opportunity to connect with other people and being close to the nature can be seen as a shift from the monotonous activities. Finding positive meaning in such ways can produce experiences of contentment, joy, love and other positive emotions.

Finding positive meaning can produce significant therapeutic effects and can cause improvement in physical as well as psychological health and well-being. Fredrickson (2000) argued that finding positive meaning produces positive emotions that broaden the modes of thinking and build enduring personal resources. The intervention strategies focusing on increasing the pleasant activities can be used to focus more directly on finding positive meaning and experiencing positive emotions.

The broaden-and-build theory emphasizes on the ways in which positive emotions are significant elements of optimal functioning and hence essential aspect of positive psychology. The important contribution that this theory makes is that it is important to cultivate positive emotions in our lives and those around us, which can transform us into better persons, leading better lives.

